

Abstract

The rapid development of social media has seen the emergence of a form of ‘influencer marketing’ that allows brands to work with key opinion leaders (KOL) to promote products, with the level of KOL attributes directly affecting consumers' perceptions of their credibility and purchasing intention. Skincare consumers seek the opinions of skincare KOLs before making purchase decisions, as consumers in the skincare space are usually unable to independently judge whether a skincare product is suitable for them through the ingredient list. This study is centered on the skincare KOLs, using the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) as the basis of the theoretical model. 150 valid survey data were collected by questionnaire, using Baron and Kenny's Method for Mediation to investigate the impacts of the four attributes (expertise, popularity, commercial transparency, and degree of commercialization) on KOL credibility perception and purchasing intentions, and to analyze the mediating effect of KOL credibility perception on the relationship between both. The study results show that expertise has a significant positive effect on consumers' perceptions of KOL credibility and purchase intention, with perceptions of KOL credibility playing a partially mediating role. Popularity has a direct positive effect on consumers' purchase intention, but no mediating effect exists in the path. Commercial transparency and degree of commercialization are not significantly related to the effect on KOL credibility perception and purchase intention. However, the near-significant p-value of commercialization suggests that there is a small probability that it may directly cause negative damage to KOL Credibility Perception. Besides that, this study provides a theoretical complement to the application of the ELM in social media and real consumption situations and provides suggestions for marketers to optimize their strategies based on the results.